

Episode 126: About *NOX*

The rainy season has arrived, and I'm suffering from the daily mugginess. The most challenging season of the year has come.

My new weapon for this year's rainy season is long pants. Translated into Japanese, that's "suteteko." My wife bought me several for my birthday present this year. Various print patterns, somewhat fashionable and cute ones. I wear these in my home work room. Oh, I definitely don't wear them outside (laugh).

Made from smooth materials and reaching just below the knees, they properly cover sweat-prone areas like behind the knees. They absorb sweat quite well. These "fashionable suteteko" really work!

I'm writing this manuscript today in such "fashionable suteteko" attire (laugh). I wonder if these will become trendy this summer? I'd be happy if they did.

Now then.

"Tsujita-san, here! Sorry to keep you waiting," the director personally handed me a white box DVD the other day. Oh right, completed version samples distributed to production staff are called "white boxes." These used to be distributed as unmarked white case home video tapes, hence "white box." These days they're usually DVDs.

Do you know the anime *Wakfu*? It's an animation currently broadcasting to great acclaim on French TV. The story is otherworld adventure? A children's work. Production is ANKAMA ANIMATION. A French company. Made based on Flash. Actually last year, I participated in what was essentially a "side story" of this *Wakfu*. That was *NOX* (original title "Special Episode NOXIMILIEN").

The director is Choi Eun-Young. Storyboard, direction, and partial key animation are also by Eun-Young. Oh right, Eun-Young is this kind of person.

I first worked with Eun-Young on *Casshern Sins* #20, and we somehow hit it off (laugh). So I was invited to this *NOX*.

Character design is by Yuasa Masaaki, animation director is Mihara Michio, art is by Santiago-san who is French. And I'm in charge of colour design. Incidentally, colour direction is by Akimoto Yuki-san, who's also working hard on *Tatami Galaxy*. The original *Wakfu* is Flash animation, but this *NOX* is full hand-drawn 2D animation.

I joined last summer. Right during *STRONG WORLD* production, working in parallel. I was handed character designs and told "It's Yuasa-san's design," and I remember thinking "Heh, that Yuasa-san." Two months later I'd meet him for the first time on *Tatami Galaxy* (laugh). That was also my first time meeting Animation Director Mihara-san. Since I'd been reading Mihara-san's Anime Style columns, I was actually quite nervous when first meeting him (laugh).

The production studio is Arai Yakushi. Actually ANKAMA's Japanese studio is located here. It's incredibly close to my home, and every time I passed by I'd think "What's this stylish office?" This lovely building has Japanese and French staff working together. Plus Eun-Young is Korean, making it an incredibly global studio.

French animators also participated in this *NOX*, including Art's Santiago-san and composite staff (ah, sorry, I forgot the name (sweat))—also French. When everyone gathered in the conference room for meetings, English became the common language. The director personally interpreted (laugh).

My work started as usual with character colour design, first creating a "how about this?" proposal with me, Eun-Young, and Mihara-san. Then we'd show it to French staff for their opinions. Since it's a work broadcasting in France, their opinions were important. And this was quite interesting.

We "Far East Asia group" and the French people had quite different colour sensibilities. Plus their sense of ethnic things was very different from ours. Ah, I see, very European. Various races and ethnicities are routinely everywhere, and not about discrimination—there are various historical concerns.

Opinions erupted particularly about clothing colours. Since they're "family," I'd coordinated colours so parents and children looked like the same colours, but "a clan wearing same-coloured clothes becomes too much of a chosen people ideological visual." I see—when cultures differ, feelings about such things are so different too.

Listening well to such opinions, I reconstructed. Finally the director decided "We'll go with this!" and based on those basic colours, I proceeded with each scene's colour design.

This work's obsession on the animation side was "line expression." With ordinary 2D works we make, everything starts by digitally binarizing line art, but doing that inevitably makes lines hard and thin, losing the swell, thickness—essentially "line expression"—that pencil drawings possess.

How to create screens that utilise that "line expression" while being digital painted, so-called 2D anime screens? Trying various methods, we arrived at laying raw line art that wasn't binarized over painted material with binarized lines during photography. Main line colours were also calculated and decided to match this technique. It demonstrated wonderful effects on beautiful backgrounds.

Production continued until the very end of last year, and Eun-Young took completed footage to France. After dubbing and sound work, it was completed early this spring. There was a completion preview at ANKAMA-JAPAN's Arai Yakushi studio, but both Yuasa-san and I couldn't attend due to *Tatami Galaxy* meetings. So with this white box I received, I could watch the sound-complete version for the first time.

Wow, good feeling. It became better screens than we aimed for. While *Wakfu* is for children, this *NOX* seems aimed at slightly older demographics. It's a somewhat scary story. The screen is also heavy and frightening. I'm slightly worried whether small children watching *Wakfu* might get traumatised (laugh).

I think the main feature movie will officially appear on ANKAMA's site eventually, but currently only trailer movies can be watched. The main feature might also be on YouTube? Those curious might try searching. Oh, incidentally, it's in French (laugh).

Now, that Eun-Young participates in *Tatami Galaxy* Episode 10 "Four-and-a-Half Tatami Idealist" for storyboard and direction. It broadcasts this week in Kanto. Everyone please support it. Please look forward to it!

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